Delhi's Public Library

Collapsing use, an under-spent grant, and the gap between provision and a public

Right 2 Read Campaign

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Abstract

A public library is only public if people can reach it and use it. This paper asks whether the Delhi Public Library (DPL) — founded in 1951 as a Government of India / UNESCO pilot public library, and still run as a central, Ministry-of-Culture autonomous body — meets that standard, against three tests a city library should pass: is it dense and reachable enough; do people use it; and is it funded, and does it spend, to deliver the service. We answer with DPL's own annual reports across fifteen years.

The findings are stark. Public use has not merely stagnated, it has collapsed: annual book issues fell about 77 percent, from a peak of 1,169,734 in 2010-11 to 274,751 in 2023-24, and the inflow of new stock all but stopped — books added to the collection fell from roughly 78,000 a year to about 3,100. Membership grew through the 2010s to a 2019-20 peak of 189,235 and has since fallen to 110,534. The fiscal picture is the opposite of starvation and just as damaging: DPL is generously funded by its central grant but does not spend it. In 2023-24 it carried Rs 4.78 crore unspent against a Rs 36.4 crore grant; in 2021-22 it returned Rs 1.58 crore to the Ministry. In purchasing-power terms its library-materials spend per resident is a tiny fraction of a functioning system's. Where Ahmedabad's municipal network spends on establishment rather than books, Delhi's central library does not spend at all. And the network barely reaches: with all 35 fixed branches now located, only about 20 percent of Delhi's wards lie within a 15-minute walk of one, and half the branches sit off the Metro grid that could carry people to them.

The case: why a city library must be reachable

Before measuring Delhi, we should say plainly what a public library is for, and why its reach matters. Three claims set the standard the rest of the paper tests.

A public library is civic infrastructure, not a book warehouse. Its purpose is use. Ranganathan's laws are blunt about it: books are for use, every reader should find their book and every book its reader, and the reader's time should be saved (Ranganathan 1931); the IFLA-UNESCO manifesto frames the public library as a local institution for education, information, and democratic life (International Federation of Library Associations and Institutions and UNESCO 2022) — the very mandate under which DPL itself was created as a UNESCO pilot in 1951. Contemporary scholarship reads the library as social and intellectual infrastructure, a low-threshold public place to be provisioned and judged like other urban systems (Mattern 2014; Klinenberg 2018). In India the institution has been named a bedrock of democratic and anti-caste life (Liang and Gupta 2024) and just as routinely left to decay by the governments that own it (Chitralekha 2014; Pyati 2009). For a campaign for the right to read, the library is the public's standing claim on knowledge; whether people can reach and use it is the whole question.

A library is public only if it is reachable. Most users of an Indian city library do not arrive by car; they walk or take a bus, and the residents who depend most on a nearby branch — children, students, women, older and poorer people — are exactly those least able to travel far. Use falls with distance: the spatial-access literature treats proximity, travel time, and distance decay as central, not incidental (Penchansky and Thomas 1981; Luo and Wang 2003). Cities now plan deliberately for short-walk access to everyday public facilities — the "15-minute city" and, since 2016, China's "15-minute community life circle," which set pedestrian-distance coverage of daily public facilities, libraries among them, as a measured governance target (Yang and Qian 2024; Ma et al. 2023). Where walking ends, buses and the metro must extend the reach, and the IFLA service guidelines are explicit that service points belong where people already converge, tiered outward so everyone is reached (IFLA Public Library Section 2010); a nearby stop is not yet access, since the first- and last-mile is where journeys break down, especially for women (Roy et al. 2024).

This is not a parochial or a Northern standard. Reachable, well-served neighbourhoods are what the major quantitative livability frameworks measure and reward — the Economist Intelligence Unit's liveability ranking, the Mercer quality-of-living index, the Social Progress Index, and the wider field of more than 150 city-benchmarking efforts (Wolfmayr 2024; Kitchin et al. 2015) — and the cities that consistently top them (Vienna, Vancouver, Melbourne, Geneva) are those with dense, walkable, transit-served public provision. The same coverage logic is now codified across the Global South, most explicitly in China's life circle (Yang and Qian 2024; Ma et al. 2023), and runs through Southern urban practice more broadly, where reliable access to shared services is the test of a functioning city (Bhan 2019; *The Routledge Companion to Planning in the Global South* 2017). We borrow the coverage logic, not the league tables: rankings can be naive and politically loaded, treating the city as a scoreboard rather than a public (Kitchin et al. 2015). Indian researchers have documented the same deficits at home — transport policy that omits equity (Verma et al. 2021), streets captured by the private automobile (Gopakumar 2020), shrinking and unequal public open space (Agarwal et al. 2023), and a long contest over India's "open space" and "public place" (Chakrabarty 1991). The public library is one more public amenity inside this pattern.

Together these set the tests for Delhi: is the system dense and reachable enough; do people use it; and is it funded — and spent — to deliver. The measurement that follows serves those questions, not the reverse.

Measurement frame

We use the IFLA Library Map of the World grammar, built on ISO 2789 definitions: service points, registered users, visits, loans, staff, internet access, and collections, all comparable per population (International Federation of Library Associations and Institutions 2026; ISO 2789 2022). ISO 11620 adds the performance question — not how much a library owns, but how well its resources convert into use (ISO 11620 2023). A branch count alone can make a weak system look healthy; "access," likewise, can be merely nominal (Mickiewicz 2016). Access is not distance: a defensible accessibility model needs demand origins, supply capacity, travel time, catchments, and distance decay, not nearest-facility distance alone (Guagliardo 2004; Luo and Wang 2003; Luo and Qi 2009; Nisar et al. 2018). Five rules carry into the analysis: normalize by population; separate service points from effective capacity; treat public funding as an input, not a result; read user fees as a possible barrier even when fiscally minor; and keep spatial access as a proxy until travel-time routing is built.

Data and methods

The unit of analysis is the Delhi Public Library system, a central Ministry-of-Culture autonomous body, not a municipal network. We read it against a single external benchmark — the Toronto Public Library — used only as a yardstick for what a functioning municipal system discloses and reaches.

For Delhi we use DPL's own annual reports, 2009-10 to 2023-24, for membership, issues (circulation), reading-room attendance, collection, additions, and — from 2021-22, when the lines are disclosed — finance (Delhi Public Library 2024). We normalize by the National Capital Territory population, taken as 19.0 million (2020 projection; the 2011 Census figure of 16.79 million is retained only for audit), and report a National Capital Region shadow catchment (27-32 million) as a sensitivity, not the primary denominator, because DPL's service jurisdiction is the NCT. For Toronto we use the city's open data and 2024 published facts against a 2.79 million-resident base. Finance is compared in purchasing-power-parity international dollars where both sides disclose it. All figures are produced from these source tables by `scripts/make_delhi_library_paper_figures.py`; the full source inventory is in the appendix.

The spatial layers are now built, with their limits stated up front. Of DPL's 111 published locations, 35 are fixed service points (fixed, zonal, sub-branch, and community libraries), and all 35 are now located at verified or rooftop precision — 28 of them from DPL's own published map links, the rest from rooftop geocoding. Delhi's Metro is joined from OpenStreetMap (246 stations and the line geometry) and the DTC/cluster bus network from the Open Transit Data GTFS feed (10,559 stops; 2,400-plus routes); ward boundaries are the pre-2022 set (the 2022 unified-MCD 250-ward delimitation is not openly available as geometry). This is enough to compute ward walk-access and transit-siting for the fixed network, which we do below; the maps should be read as indicative of sparsity, not a survey, and mobile service points are excluded because they are not fixed access.

Delhi I — who uses it, and the decade of collapse

DPL's own reports show public use collapsing across fifteen years (Figure 1).

The underlying values:

Year	Issues (circulation)	Members	Books added	Collection
2009-10	1,039,977	64,883	77,872	1,552,000
2010-11	**1,169,734**	73,467	33,868	1,608,813
2013-14	1,081,767	107,276	23,565	1,694,695
2016-17	700,412	159,200	38,256	1,706,326
2018-19	814,858	187,138	27,958	1,694,950
2019-20	477,008	**189,235**	13,310	1,596,125
2020-21	112,946	165,854	2,504	1,602,290
2022-23	258,180	148,094	9,947	1,536,905
2023-24	274,751	110,534	3,108	1,527,531

Three movements run through the record. First, circulation collapsed: issues peaked at 1,169,734 in 2010-11, were already sliding through the mid-2010s, and stand at 274,751 in 2023-24 — a fall of about 77 percent, with the post-2019 crash never recovering. At 19 million residents that is roughly 0.014 issues per resident a year. Second, the collection stopped being renewed: books added fell from 77,872 in

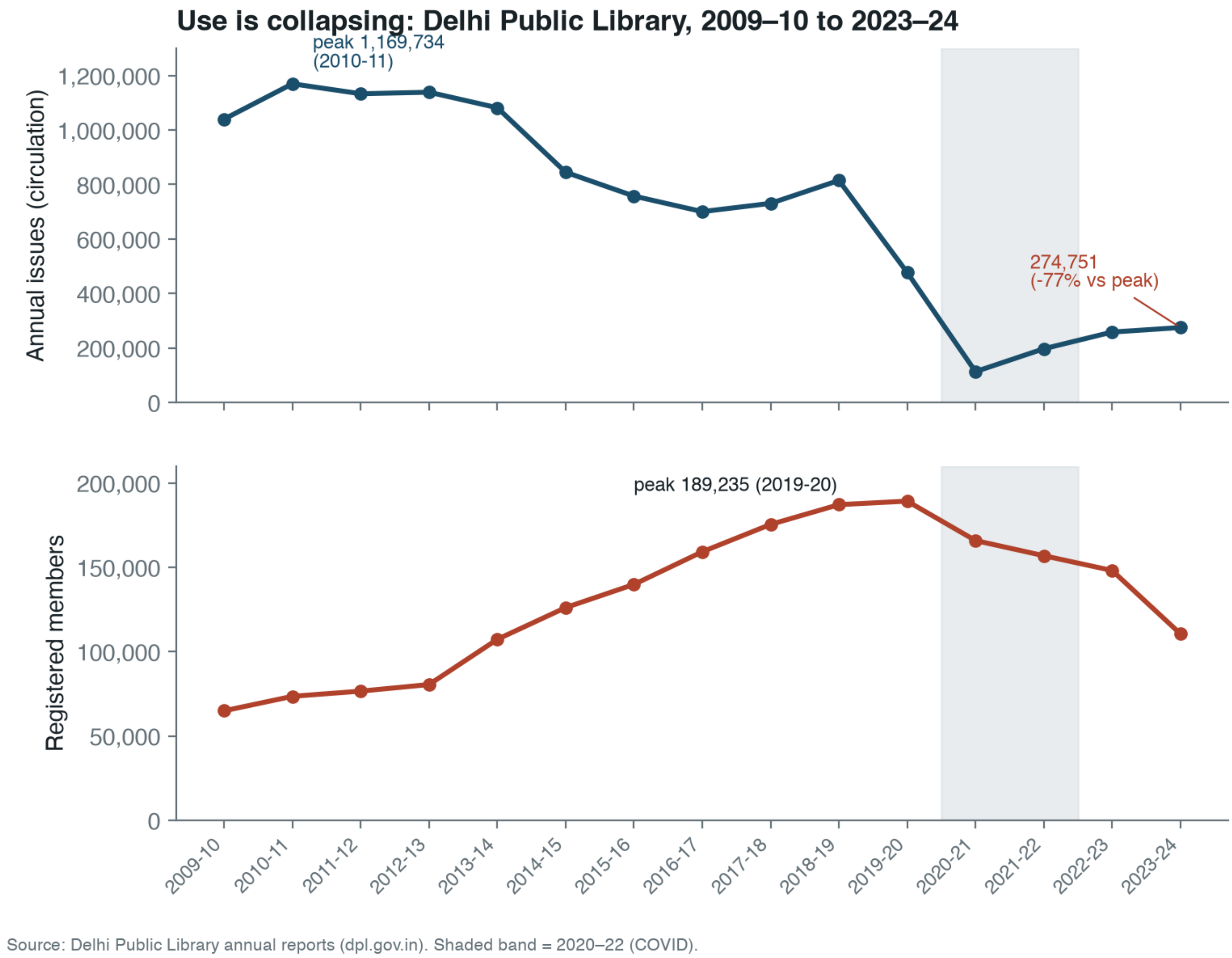

Figure 1: Annual issues (circulation) and registered members, Delhi Public Library, 2009-10 to 2023-24. Issues peak in 2010-11 and fall about 77 percent; membership peaks in 2019-20, then declines.

2009-10 to about 3,100 in 2023-24, and the total collection has shrunk slightly since 2018-19. A library that adds almost no new books gives the public little reason to return. Third, membership tells a softer but consistent story: it grew through the 2010s to 189,235 in 2019-20, then fell by more than 40 percent to 110,534 — about 0.58 percent of NCT residents. Growing the roll while circulation fell means the members it had were already using it less; shedding the roll since means it is losing even nominal reach.

Delhi II — funded, but not spent

Delhi's fiscal pathology is the mirror image of underfunding. DPL is a centrally funded institution that does not spend what it is given (Figure 2).

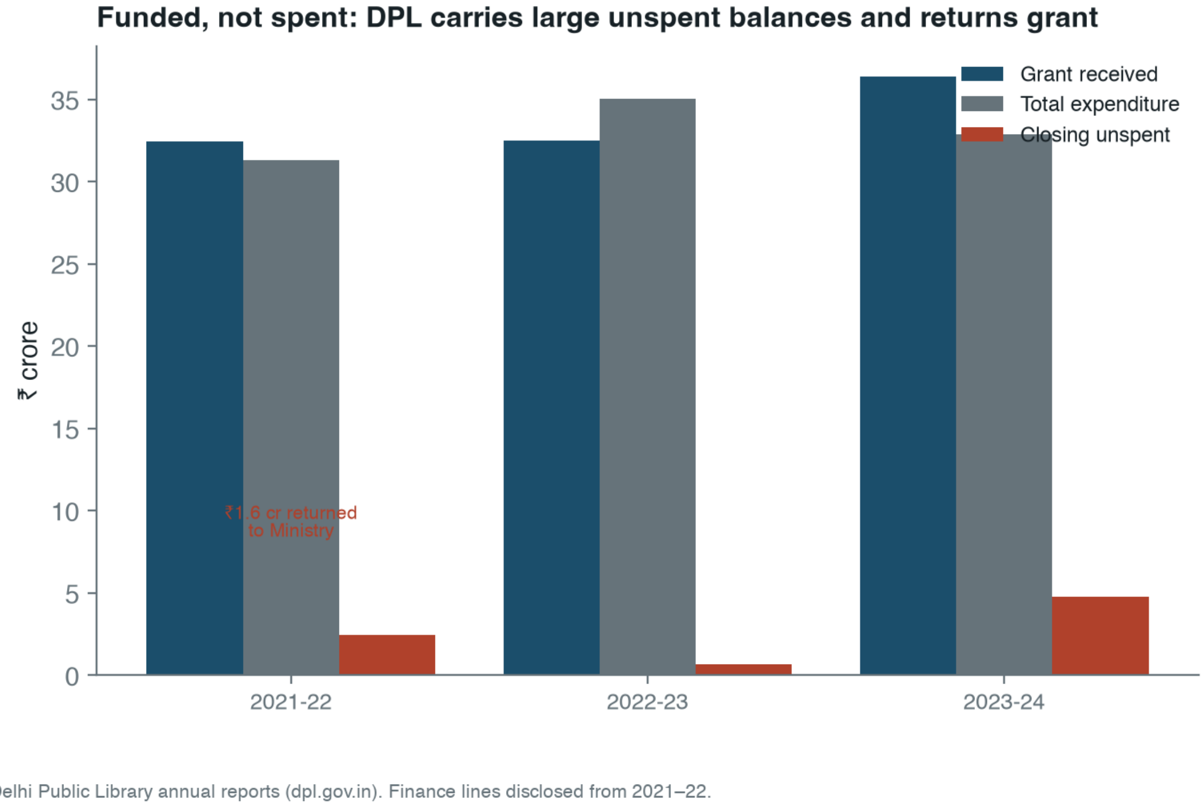

Figure 2: Grant received, total expenditure, and closing unspent balance, Delhi Public Library, 2021-22 to 2023-24. DPL carries large unspent balances and returns grant to the Ministry.

In 2023-24 DPL received a grant of about Rs 36.4 crore, spent about Rs 32.9 crore, and carried Rs 4.78 crore — roughly an eighth of the grant — unspent into the next year. In 2021-22 it returned Rs 1.58 crore of public money to the Ministry as unspent. This is not a system rationing scarce funds; it is a system that cannot, or does not, convert its budget into service. The materials line makes the point sharply: in purchasing-power-parity terms, DPL's library-materials spend per resident is on the order of a thousandth of Toronto's — consistent with adding three thousand books a year to serve a city of nineteen million. Money is reaching the institution. It is not reaching the shelves, and it is not reaching the public.

Delhi III — is it dense and reachable enough?

Start with density. On a conservative count DPL operates about 40 service points (fixed libraries plus mobile buses) for 19 million residents — roughly 2.1 per million, against Toronto's 34 per million, a sixteen-fold difference before any travel-time disadvantage is measured. Even on the most inclusive count of DPL touchpoints (about 163, including mobile service points and book-reading centres) the system is thin relative to the population it nominally serves.

Density understates the problem, because the fixed branches are not spread to where people live. Mapping all 35 fixed branches against Delhi's wards (Figure 3), only **57 of 290 wards — about 20 percent — fall within a 1.2 km (roughly 15-minute) walk of a fixed DPL branch**, and the median ward sits **2.53 km** from its nearest one; put spatially, barely **9 percent of the city's land area** lies within that walk. The network is also lopsided: its mean centre sits about **7 km east-northeast of Delhi's geographic centre**, pulled into the old core (New Delhi, North, Central, and Shahdara districts hold most branches) while outer districts — South West, East, North East — have one each. For most of Delhi, the nearest public library is not walkable.

Transit only partly rescues the reach, and unevenly by mode. Against Delhi's Metro — one of the densest rapid-transit networks in the country — only **16 of the 35 fixed branches sit within 800 m of a Metro station, and just 7 within 400 m** (Figure 4): half the network is off the *rapid*-transit grid. The DTC and cluster bus network does markedly better — **27 of the 35 branches are within 400 m of a bus stop** (of 10,559 stops citywide) — so most branches are reachable by bus, the slower and more crowded mode, while the faster Metro that could widen their catchment largely misses them. Siting new service on the Metro corridors where Delhi already moves is the most direct way to extend reach without building a single new branch.

Two caveats bound these maps. First, the library points are now firm — all 35 fixed branches are placed at verified or rooftop precision, 28 of them from DPL's own published map links — so the residual uncertainty is the ward layer (the pre-2022 set), not the branch locations. Second, and more important, the 1.2 km walk is a deliberately strict floor. Many Delhi residents do not reach a branch on foot: they take an auto-rickshaw, an app-cab (Ola/Uber), a two-wheeler, a cycle-rickshaw, or a bicycle, and this pedestrian measure counts none of those modes — so it understates who *could* in principle reach a library, and the Metro cut (Figure 4) captures only one slice of that wider, motorised catchment. The walk standard is kept all the same because it is the right test for the readers a public library most exists to serve — children, students, older people, and the carless poor, for whom the short walk is the only free mode. The pattern is robust to both caveats: a sparse network, concentrated in the core, only loosely tied to the networks that move the rest of the city.

Toronto, briefly: a background yardstick

Toronto is not the subject of this paper; it is a reference for what a functioning municipal library discloses and reaches. On shared, population-normalized indicators:

Indicator	Delhi (DPL)	Toronto	Toronto/Delhi	Comparability
Service points per million residents	2.1	34.0	16.2x	Medium
Collection items per 1,000 residents	80.4	3,500	43.5x	Medium
Registered members, share of residents	0.58%	not normalized		Partial
Issues / borrowings per resident	0.014	10.0	~690x	Medium

Indicator	Delhi (DPL)	Toronto	Toronto/Delhi	Comparability
Reading-room / branch visits per resident	0.018	4.8	~250x	Partial
Library-materials spend per resident (PPP)	very low	high	~1,480x	Medium

Toronto is denser, deeper, and far more used. The borrowing gap is roughly 690 times per resident — and, as with Ahmedabad, it dwarfs any plausible spending gap, because Delhi's problem is not a shortage of grant but a failure to spend it. The reading-room and visit rows are kept as partial: DPL reports reading-room attendance, not all branch visits, so its visit figure is understated. One row is reported without a clean ratio because DPL's registered-member stock and Toronto's new-card registrations are different objects.

What Delhi should do

First, treat DPL as a public-use system, not a custodial collection. The metrics that matter — issues, active members, books added — are all disclosed and all falling; a credible target is stated against them, not against the existence of branches.

Second, spend the grant on the service. A library that returns money to the Ministry and adds three thousand books a year is failing a budget problem in reverse: the fix is procurement, hours, staffing, and new stock, not more allocation. The unspent balance is, in effect, a measure of the service not delivered.

Third, build for reach. DPL is sparse — about two service points per million against a functioning system's thirty-plus — and the mapped branches reach only about 20 percent of wards within a walk and sit half off the Metro. The immediate, low-cost step is to place new service on Delhi's Metro and bus corridors, which already carry the residents DPL is meant to serve, rather than leaving the network bunched in the old core.

Fourth, name the governance. DPL is a central Government-of-India body sitting inside Delhi's fragmented NCT/MCD/NDMC arrangement; accountability for its decline is diffuse by design. Saying who is responsible for use, renewal, and spending is the precondition for fixing any of it.

Data gaps and next work

DPL disclosure still lacks several IFLA-style fields: physical visits (as distinct from reading-room attendance), e-book and digital use, full-time staff, internet access points, and branch-level hours and capacity. The two highest-value extensions are: extending the disclosed finance series back before 2021-22 to date the onset of under-spending; and adding the per-branch physical detail DPL does not publish in one place — reading-room capacity, opening hours, staff, and internet access — which a short RTI or site survey could supply to turn the reach maps into a service audit.

Conclusion

The Delhi Public Library fails the tests a city library should pass. It is sparse — about two service points per million residents — and what little exists is bunched in the old core: only about 20 percent of wards are within a short walk of a fixed branch, and half the network sits off the Metro. Its public use has collapsed: issues down about 77 percent over a decade, new stock down to a trickle, membership

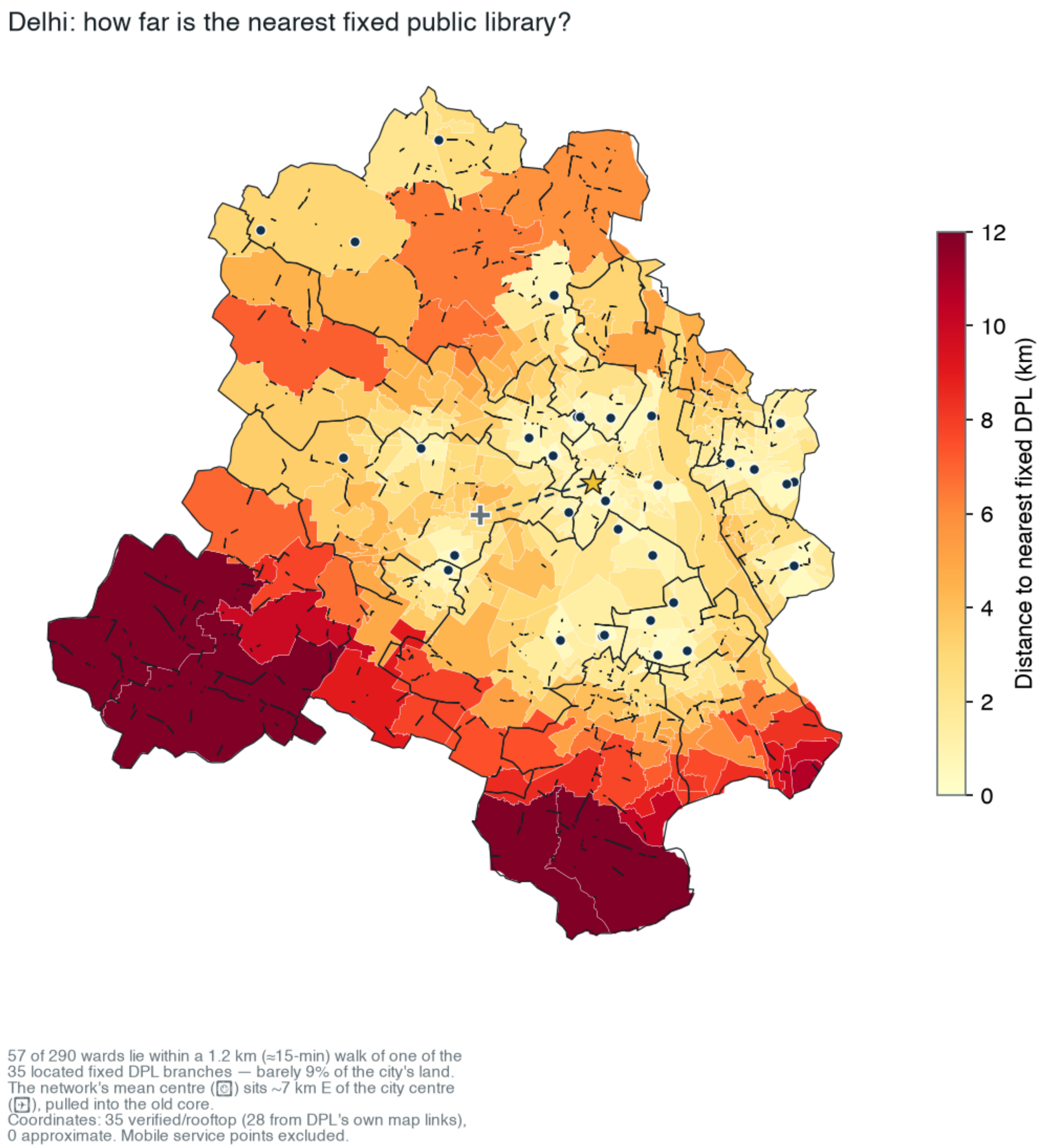

Figure 3: Distance from each Delhi ward to its nearest fixed DPL branch. Only about 20 percent of wards lie within a 1.2 km walk and barely 9 percent of the city's land area; the periphery is largely unserved. Coordinates: all 35 verified/rooftop (28 from DPL's own published map links); mobile service points excluded.

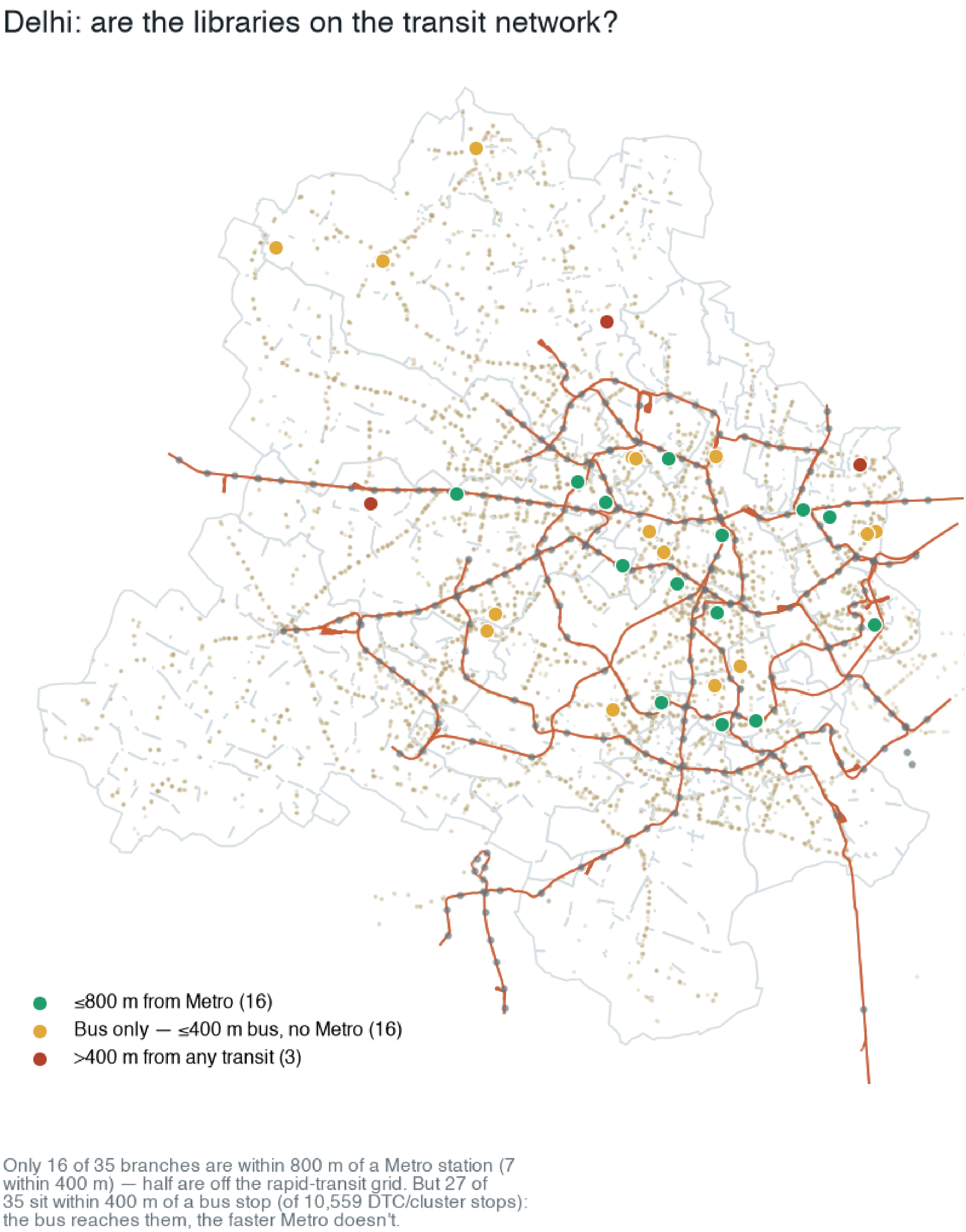

Figure 4: Fixed DPL branches against Delhi's full transit network — Metro lines and stations (OpenStreetMap) over the DTC/cluster bus-stop web (Open Transit Data GTFS, 10,559 stops). Green = within 800 m of a Metro station; amber = bus-served only (within 400 m of a bus stop but off the Metro); red = beyond 400 m of any transit. Half the network is off the rapid-transit grid, but the bus reaches almost all of it.

falling since 2019-20. And its money does not move: a central grant carried unspent and returned to the Ministry while the shelves go unrenewed. Toronto, used only as a yardstick, borrows on the order of 690 times more per resident — a gap that has nothing to do with Delhi lacking funds. The practical target is not a grander central library but a reachable, well-stocked, fully-spent public system, sited where Delhi's residents already are and measured every year on the use it actually delivers.

Sources and reproducibility

Delhi. Membership, issues, reading-room attendance, collection, additions, and finance are from the Delhi Public Library's annual reports, 2009-10 to 2023-24 (Delhi Public Library 2024). Location counts are from DPL's published zone listings; NCT and NCR population denominators are from Census 2011 and MoHFW Technical Group projections.

Toronto (background yardstick). Branch, collection, borrowing, visit, and registration figures are from Toronto Open Data and Toronto Public Library's 2024 published facts (City of Toronto Open Data 2026; Toronto Public Library 2026a); finance from the 2026 budget (Toronto Public Library 2026b).

Standards. Indicators follow the IFLA Library Map of the World grammar and ISO 2789 / ISO 11620 definitions (International Federation of Library Associations and Institutions 2026; ISO 2789 2022, ISO 11620 2023); the normative and siting frame draws on the IFLA-UNESCO Public Library Manifesto (2022) and Service Guidelines (2010) (International Federation of Library Associations and Institutions and UNESCO 2022; IFLA Public Library Section 2010).

The IFLA frame is used as an indicator grammar, not a claim that every field has a single universal target: matched indicators are separated from partial ones, and where a system does not disclose a metric the absence is kept as a data gap rather than inferred. Finance is compared in PPP international dollars (World Bank conversion). All charts are reproducible from the source tables by the figure script in the project repository.

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